

SEDAR 78 South Atlantic Spanish Mackerel Research Recommendations

The research recommendations from the SEDAR 78 panel were as follows:

- Development of a fishery-independent survey for pelagic species would decrease reliance on a fishery-dependent index of abundance that has unexplained trends in residual values in recent years.
- Examine how schooling or migratory dynamics may influence the catchability of the species. In particular, research the assumption of the hyperstability of indices that sample the schooling portion of the stock.
- Age-dependent natural mortality was estimated by indirect methods (Lorenzen) for this assessment. Telemetry- and conventional-tagging programs can provide alternative estimates of natural mortality. Investigate new methods for determining point estimates for natural mortality.

Sampling Recommendations

- Limited information is available for shrimp bycatch in the Atlantic. Comprehensive observer coverage across space and time are needed to adequately capture the scale and size distribution of bycatch for Spanish mackerel and other species.
- The general recreational discards have increased dramatically in the last 2 years of this assessment. A better understanding of the size composition and mortality of discarded fish would improve the assessment, especially if discards continue to increase due to effort or future management changes.
- Implement systematic age sampling for the general recreational and commercial sectors. Age samples were important for this assessment for determining key parameters but sample sizes were limited, particularly for the general recreational sector, commercial handline and commercial cast net sectors, which account for the majority of the recent landings.